TO SET OUT ON THE ROAD TO $1 TRILLION, THE STATE HAS SIGNED 207 MoUs WORTH Rs 2.2 LAKH CRORE

predecessors. Unlike the late AIADMK leader J. Jayalalithaa, who as chief minister would have cabinet ministers prostrating before her, Stalin shuns sycophancy. Given his many years in politics, he is a patient listener.

Even before his party had won the election, he and other leaders had gone from district to district to get a measure of people's problems and based the party's manifesto on their demands. After he took over as CM, under an initiative called Ungal Thoguthiyil Muthalamaichar (CM in your constituency), Stalin makes it a point to visit all the 234 assembly constituencies by turn, listen to the electorate's grievances and address them. At the CM's office in Fort St George, a huge digital dashboard constantly updates him about the progress of various schemes and projects and whether targets are being met. Stalin believes in frequent review meetings with his ministers. Being the party president, he also has the last word on political issues.

Yet, the current round of State of the States throws up some disturbing findings about Tamil Nadu that the chief minister would do well to heed. While the state has been consistent in winning the best performing accolade for the past five years, its overall ranking in the most improved category is not as flattering. The state had slipped to the bottom of the pool in 2019 and 2020, ranking 19th among 20 states. It moved up to 16th place in 2021, and remains there this year too. Its economic performance in the most improved category has dropped in comparison to other states—from 8th in 2018 to 13th this year. Likewise, in infrastructure, it was at the bottom of the list in 2020, and though it has moved to 17th place in 2022, the state needs to work hard towards improving its score. Again, while Tamil Nadu has shown vast improvement in agriculture, health and governance, its progress in education and inclusive development are modest. Worryingly, in law and order and entrepreneurship, the state's ranking has dipped considerably in the past two years.

Of course, there is plenty that other states can learn from Tamil Nadu. But then. in many areas there's plenty the state can learn from its compatriots too. That is also the purpose of INDIA TODAY's State of the States survey—to foster constructive competition and cooperation among states. ■

CATEGORY	WEIGHTAGE FOR BEST PERFORMING CATEGORY	WEIGHTAGE FOR MOST IMPROVED CATEGORY
ECONOMY	300	300
INFRASTRUCTURE	280	280
AGRICULTURE	320	320
HEALTH	240	160
EDUCATION	200	200
LAW & ORDER	140	140
GOVERNANCE	120	120
INCLUSIVE DEVELOPMENT	100	100
ENTREPRENEURSHIP	80	80
TOURISM	140	140
ENVIRONMENT	90	90
CLEANLINESS	70	70
TOTAL	**2,080**	**2,000**

parameters were finalised in consultation with the experts, INDIA TODAY editors and the MDRA team.

Based on the parameters and attributes, a comprehensive data collection exercise was undertaken. MDRA researchers cross-examined the data collected from highly credible sources such as the Census, Reserve Bank of India, NITI Aayog, respective ministries and departments and state governments. To ensure a fair comparison, it was ensured that no state got unfair advantage on account of size, population or any other aspect. It was necessary therefore to normalise the data based on population or geographical size, as required. The data collected for each attribute was cleaned, normalised and standardised to make it comparable. The most recent data for each state (mostly 2021-2022, 2020-21, 2019-20, 2018-19 and 2017-18) was taken and analysed to evaluate the best performing states. To compare and rank the most improved states, compounded annual growth rates (CAGR) on each attribute for the past five years were used. Based on the weights determined for each attribute, sectoral rankings were arrived at. Parameter-level weights were used to determine the overall best performing and most improved states.

A large MDRA team, led by Abhishek Agrawal (executive director), Abnish Jha (project director), Vaibhav Gupta (assistant research manager), Aditya Srivastava (assistant research executive) and Manveer Singh (senior executive-EDP) and assisted by statisticians and econometricians, worked on this voluminous project from July to November 2022. ■